

CHAPTER 21



Subaltern Classics in Anti- and Post-Colonial Literatures in English

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Viewed from the perspective of anti- and post-colonial anglophone literature, for the most part the classics are not the ancient Greek and Roman classics; instead this status is reserved for canonical works of English literature, including the works of Shakespeare, Milton, Wordsworth, Coleridge, Austen, and Tennyson. An example from an influential work of post-colonial theory is illustrative here: in *Maps of Englishness: Writing Identity in the Culture of Colonialism* (1996), the impetus for Simon Gikandi's critique of Englishness is the observation that the 'Great Tradition' of English literature excludes writers on the peripheries of colonial culture, although these allegedly peripheral cultures have contributed to the very identity of Englishness of which the tradition is held to be an expression.¹ Gikandi's critique focuses both on the historical role of colonial cultures in contributing to the making of English literature, as well as the post-colonial identity of English literature in the present. Before Gikandi, Robert Crawford, a poet and professor of Scottish literature, proposed the rubric of 'devolving English literature' to articulate the need to devolve attention and energy away from English literature conceived of as a central, homogeneous tradition identical with a narrow conception of English nationalism, towards literatures written on the margins of England, which have for centuries 'been challenging, interrogating, and even structuring the supposed "centre"'.²

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Literatures in English commonly excluded from the tradition of English literature include ~~the anglophone works of Indian authors, African authors, Australasian authors, Caribbean authors,~~ Canadian authors, and Scots and Irish authors, in spite of the fact that ~~these authors all write in English and~~ are numbered among the foremost works of modern and contemporary world literature. Authors of global literatures in English have developed their own formulas for critiquing a monocultural tradition of Great English literature, and several of them have actively resisted incorporation into an English literature in which they are subaltern, colonized co-workers. Ngugi wa Thiong'o famously took part in a campaign to abolish the English department at the University of Nairobi,³ and subsequently turned from English to Gikuyu as the language of his novels. Seamus Heaney formally declared his non-belonging to the tradition of English literature in the verse manifesto *An Open Letter* (1983), in which he denounced his inclusion, as an Irish poet, in a collection entitled *The Penguin Book of Contemporary British Poetry* (my underlining), edited by Blake Morrison and Andrew Motion and published in 1982.⁴ As Heaney quips in the penultimate line of the poem: 'But British, no, the name's not right.'⁵ (*An Open Letter*, p. 13). For her part, Marlene Nourbese Philip has written memorably of the 'anguish that is English' language for a Canadian woman writer from Trinidad and Tobago and her poetics are informed by the linguistic goal of decentring English.⁶

Although there are strands of anti- and post-colonial literature in which Greek and Roman classics are tarnished by association with modern empires and colonial structures of power, there are also many classical receptions in anti- and post-colonial literatures in English in which Greek and Roman classics are used to challenge the idea of a single 'great' or 'classical' tradition.⁷ At the same time, Greek and Roman classics offer a rich source of literature and myth that circumvents 'English literature' as a national institution. However, while Greek and Roman classics might offer a way round the 'great tradition' of English literature, their very status as 'classics' would seem to estrange them from the ~~subaltern subject matter~~ that recurs in anti- and post-colonial literatures. This chapter will examine the phenomenon of 'subaltern classics'—the use of Greek and Roman classical texts and myths to mediate and represent subaltern conditions and experiences and to give them wider currency. Similarly, although the terms 'anti-colonial' and 'post-colonial' literature might be obvious descriptors for the fiction of Walcott, Philip, Dove, and Malouf, always with nuance and qualification, the extension of these terms to Morrison and Dove, and to African American literature more broadly, is arguable. My own view is that it makes good sense to use African American thought, art, and politics to cast light on anti- and post-colonial theory and vice versa, both in terms

of the exchange and circulation of literature, ideas, and ideologies in the twentieth century and in terms of comparing respective historical experiences of oppression, exploitation, racial discrimination, and resistance. However, this exercise is most fruitful when focused around a particular strand of post-colonial theory so that its differential application can be gauged in different contexts.⁸ In this case the subaltern, as used by Gramsci and as adopted and interpreted in post-colonial theory, can function as a useful bridge highlighting affinities between authors who are often identified as post- or anti-colonial and others where this description is less clear-cut. In the interest of offering a coherent overview and a substantial discussion, I have selected authors who offer congruent models of subaltern classics. With the exception of Malouf, I focus on anglophone Caribbean and African American literature. This focus is both culturally and geographically selective; a more comprehensive study would include anti- and post-colonial classical receptions in literatures in English in Africa and India.⁹

Subaltern classics

The Gramscian concept of the subaltern has a wide sphere of reference. In addition to its significance in Gramsci's thought, it is sometimes taken to refer to the work of the Subaltern Studies Group associated with Ranjit Guha, and, perhaps most prominently, with the famous essay, 'Can the Subaltern Speak' by Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak.¹⁰ In evoking this concept here I have in mind Gramsci's broad and fairly consistent use of this term to refer to different oppressed groups (slaves, peasants, religious minorities, women, different races and ethnic groups, the proletariat and the sub-proletariat), who while their situations and degrees of empowerment will differ depending upon their historical, cultural, and political situation, have in common their restricted access to political representation and their restricted access to self-representation in literature and history.¹¹ Some of the authors discussed here, such as Marlene Nourbese Philip, clearly suit Spivak's definition of the subaltern as 'gendered muting' (the ways in which the archive is complicit in muting the voices of subaltern women), but I use the concept here primarily to refer to Gramsci's acknowledgement of different subaltern statuses and his interest in how subalterns are represented when they do not control the means of representation.

As used here, subaltern classics is, if not an oxymoron, then at the very least a provocation. By their very nomenclature, classics and the classical pronounce an elite pedigree: a category for literature and the arts that takes its name from the

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highest Roman property class.¹² Although this etymology is seldom evoked explicitly, it is echoed in popular usage. While they may be marketed for the masses and appreciated by a broad public (think of Penguin Classics and Oxford World's Classics), the classics are to artistic production what elites of wealth or birth are to contemporary society: the product of a small artistic elite regulated by an intelligentsia that comprises academics, critics, publishers, and other artists. Greek and Roman classics are part of this larger phenomenon. On the surface, classics could not be more remote from subaltern groups, many of whom lack literacy, let alone the leisure to read and access to classical literature. While not wanting to deny this basic contradiction and tension in 'subaltern classics', I am interested in the ways in which writers who identify with different subaltern positions on the grounds of (a) post- and anti-colonial consciousness, (b) their belonging to minority cultures and literatures, or, (c) their marginal position with English literature as writers of 'literatures in English' have variously used adaptations of Greek and Roman classics as a way of writing back to hegemonic traditions. They do this by exploiting the fact that the Greek and Roman texts that are the primary referents of 'classics' are themselves not 'classical' in the sense that they do not participate in the structures of elite culture and social and economic power relations that set the conditions for our contemporary world. As such, they can be used to trump and to gainsay other classical traditions—in this case classical English and/or American literature.

The classical receptions discussed in this chapter reveal that subaltern classics do not inherit or receive a classical tradition that is mired in 'Eurochronology'.¹³ This is not to say that the writers discussed here are not aware of the tradition that claims the civilizations of ancient Greece and Rome for modern Europe, or the role that appropriations of Greece and Rome have played in formations of Western cultural imperialism. As children of empire and citizens of former colonies, descendants of former slaves, or diasporic writers, these writers know imperial classical fictions full well.¹⁴ They know, for instance, the ugly history of its cooptation by the plantocracy in the Caribbean and the American South, as well as in other domains of empire. But this is all the more reason for their constructing a fresh, oppositional classical tradition in opposition to the one that already exists.

This fresh, alternative tradition rejects the idea of classics as the exclusive property of Europe and the north Atlantic. The writers engage with classics on their own cultural terms, recognizing that which is germane to their historical and cultural experience and domesticating classics according to the needs of their art. While the pluriform classical tradition in modern Europe was essentially

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characterized by a series of encounters with classics that produced vernacular versions of classical texts and myths, these vernacular versions have become their own classics, which anti- and post-colonial literatures often react against. So although vernacular classicism is an important precondition for subaltern classics (Dante's ~~Virgil is echoed in the character Omeros in Walcott~~, for instance),¹⁵ these vernacular adaptations and engagements are not necessarily 'vernacular' in the black theoretical sense, as used by critics like Houston Baker.¹⁶ Hence my use of the term subaltern classics, to denote an anti- and post-colonial tradition of engaging with the classics in sympathy with the dispossessed, the pre-proletariat, the colonized, and with minority cultures. In opting for this term I do not want to imply an overly schematic 'school', or to imply that the writers identify themselves as subaltern. The writers whom I discuss here (David Malouf, Derek Walcott, Marlene Nourbese Philip, Toni Morrison, and Rita Dove) come from different cultural backgrounds and represent four different nationalities; instead, subaltern classics names and identifies a diverse but recognizable strand of classical receptions in anti- and post-colonial literature written in English.

An anti-classical *Iliad*: David Malouf's *Ransom* (2009)


 In his 2009 novel *Ransom*, David Malouf revisits a famous scene in Homeric epic from a distinctly subaltern angle. The scene in question is Priam's supplication of Achilles for the return of Hector's body in Book 24 of the *Iliad*.¹⁷ In the *Iliad* this is a scene of self-debasement as Priam temporarily sets aside his royal status to kneel to appeal to Achilles. It is also, arguably, a scene of abjection as Priam's supplication is preceded by scenes of grovelling in the dung as he mourns for Hector.¹⁸ However, any abjection is temporary and precipitated by grief; there is no suggestion in Homer that Priam loses his royal status or develops any fellow-feeling with ordinary Trojans or Achaeans. The class structure of fictional Homeric society remains intact.

In contrast, at the core of Malouf's adaptation is an extra-Homeric mythological tradition, attested in the encyclopedic *Bibliothēkē* (*Library*) of Pseudo-Apollodorus (2.6.4), according to which Priam King of Troy was formerly the royal prince Podarces, son of Laomedon, the only one of Laomedon's sons to be spared when Heracles and Telamon sacked Troy and killed his father. According to this later source, Podarces was declared a slave but then ransomed by his sister Hesione who had been given to Telamon as a prize of war. Hence the name Priam, from the verb *priamai* 'I buy'.¹⁹ Malouf resurrects this recondite myth

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and interweaves it into his adaptation of the version of Priam's story (and those of Hector and Achilles) canonized in Homer's *Iliad*.

Not only does Malouf supplement the canonical source with a mythical prequel to the *Iliad* that derives from lost, cyclical epic, but he also supplements the supplement to add vivid details to Priam's transient enslavement. In his encyclopedia, pseudo-Apollodorus supplies the brief detail (running to about five lines of Greek text in modern editions) that Priam was formerly Podarces and that he was ransomed as a war captive; Malouf expands this detail into a fourteen-page description in which Priam narrates this suppressed chapter from his past to Hecuba, recalling his past identity as Podarces and how it felt to be a war captive whose fate hung in the balance of an arbitrary will:

'I look up now and I can still see it. It's the road my other self went down. To a life where you and I, my dear, have never met, have never found one another. To a life I have lived entirely without you. In the same body perhaps,' he holds up his arm, 'with the same loose skin, the same ache in the knee-joints and thumbs. But one that for sixty years has known only drudgery and daily humiliation and blows. And that life too, I have lived, if only in a ghostly way. And a foul-smelling mockery of this one, that at any moment can rise to my nostrils and pluck at my robe and whisper, So there you are, old man Podarces.'

'There are things,' he says, almost under his breath, 'that once we have touched them, once they have touched us, we can never throw off, however much we scrub away at ourselves, however high the gods set us. In our nostrils the stench is still there, the old filth sticks. The smell of those other—which was my smell too, the smell of the slave's life I was being dragged away to—I can never rub off.'²⁰

In Malouf's version, the psychological trauma of this experience resonates throughout the novel and explains Priam's readiness to set aside his royal status and to approach Achilles as one man to another.²¹ Moreover, Priam's identification with the common man is reinforced by the presence of a literal commoner in the character of Somax, who takes the role of Idaeus in the *Iliad* and who, for the purposes of the mission, Malouf's Priam ceremonially renames Idaeus in both an intertextual and meta-textual nod.²² As a genuine subaltern, Somax is a figure on whom Priam can project his assumptions about ordinary men and in reference to whom he can rehearse his own role as ordinary man. The name Somax does not occur in Homeric epic, or anywhere in extant Greek literature. It is Malouf's invention, presumably derived phonetically from the Greek noun *σῶμα* (*sōma*: body). In other words, the carter Somax is the embodiment of bare life, to use Agamben's term. His significance in society is confined to his mere body and the physical labour that he can do with this body as a hired labourer: he

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is ‘a plain workman’, and a ‘simple workman’.²³ His low social status is reinforced by the fact that Priam is able to strip him of his name: outside of his kin and the humble circles in which he moves, this name has no broader resonance.²⁴

In fact, for Malouf, the character of Somax represents those whose stories are not told—whose lives are insufficiently epic or story-worthy to count. Commenting on the genesis of *Ransom* in the Afterword, Malouf explains his circumvention of the canonical, Homeric version in terms of the politics of storytelling and artistic representation:

It [this book] re-enters the world of the *Iliad* to recount the story of Achilles, Patroclus and Hector, and, in a very different version from the original, Priam’s journey to the Greek camp. But its primary interest is in story-telling itself—why stories are told and why we need to hear them, how stories get changed in the telling—and much of what it has to tell are ‘untold tales’ found only in the margins of earlier writers.²⁵

Within the novel this focus on the politics of storytelling encompasses not just the why and the how of storytelling, but the whom as well: whose stories get told? At the close of the novel Somax emerges as the source for the version of Priam’s embassy to Achilles that we have been reading: a storyteller who is listened to, but whose part in the story is not believed on account of his humble status:

What he has to tell did happen—or so they say—but to someone else. Idaeus, the man was called, King Priam’s herald. . . . This old fellow, like most storytellers, is a stealer of other men’s tales, of other men’s lives. The whole of his own life he has spent as a poor day labourer. He is, as every one knows, a carter who, long ago, when there was a town hereabouts, went out each morning to offer himself for hire in the marketplace. . . .²⁶

It is in this sense that Malouf’s adaptation evokes an aspect of Gramsci’s concept of the subaltern, specifically the question of the representation, in history and literature, of those subaltern groups who ‘have no history’ and of whom ‘there are no traces of their history in the historical documents of the past’.²⁷ Although the introduction of Somax and the mobilization of the Priam–Podarces plot highlights the unremittingly aristocratic world of Homeric epic, Malouf’s self-consciously revisionist adaptation of Homer is not a disavowal of the politics of suffering in the *Iliad*, which are generic enough that there is potentially room for everyone.²⁸ Instead Malouf’s revision is a rejection of an elite classical tradition, in which the world of Homer is remote from the experience of the subaltern; this classical tradition has nothing to do with actual practice and the history of



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reading, in which many subaltern readers have come to Homer and other Greek and Roman classics in Europe, the Americas, the Caribbean, Africa, Asia, and Australasia.²⁹ But the ideological remoteness of classics and the classical, however challenged in the practice or reception, gives subaltern classics its contrapuntal energy and newness by insisting on the affinities between Greek and Roman classics and minority subjectivities.

After all, the translatability of the *Iliad*, and Priam's role within it, derives in large part from its cultural, political, and social universalism. The Trojans and Greeks inhabit the same world and, in the powerful embassy scene in Book 24 which forms the kernel of Malouf's adaptation, in the exchange between Priam and Achilles they acknowledge each other's kindred, interchangeable humanity. Priam puts Achilles in mind of his father Peleus and Achilles reminds Priam of Hector. Furthermore, the epic is everywhere conscious of the contingency of status in warfare. While the tradition about Priam's brush with slavery is not present in the *Iliad*, throughout the poem, Trojan characters discuss the prospect of their future enslavement with grim resignation.³⁰

Malouf's Priam is a king who is able to supplicate Achilles by retrieving the memory and experience of having been enslaved, albeit temporarily. In Malouf's account, this fellow-feeling with the other captives, who had no privileges of status to protect them, is what gives Priam the moral courage to set aside the constraints of social expectation and cultural norms and to put himself in the position of the victim:

But after all those hours of being just one among so many—the ones for whom no miraculous turn would come, who would go on waiting in the dust and heat, and be carried off at last to a lifetime of slavery—I did not feel I'd been delivered. I had experienced something I could not un-experience and would never forget. What it means for your breath to be in another's mouth, to be one of those who have no story that will ever be told.³¹

An experiment in a classical subaltern poetics: Derek Walcott's *Omeros* (1990)

This preoccupation with the politics and poetics of storytelling is also present in Derek Walcott's epic verse novel *Omeros* (1990), the most acclaimed adaptation of Homer in recent decades.³² Walcott set out to write a poem about his native island, St Lucia, which viewed from the centres of global literary production and economic and political power, is an outlying, marginal island with a developing

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economy heavily dependent on tourism.³³ In the tradition of Aimé Césaire's *Cahier d'un retour au pays natal*,³⁴ a poem that offers a defiant, anti-colonial depiction of the neighbouring island of Martinique, Walcott emphasizes the humility of the island and the subaltern status of many of the protagonists while simultaneously insisting that they are the island's pride and that its nature, culture, and history stand comparison, on their own terms, with any 'epic' subject matter. At the same time, the poem's self-consciously anti-classical subject coexists with classical poetic form and the adoption of Homeric epic for key filaments of the plot. Over the course of *Omeros*, Walcott explores and ultimately tries to resolve this tension by making classical epic subservient to the contemporary reality of St Lucia and the poem's everyday fictional protagonists. The poet-narrator, whose identity is part native and part tourist, uses the classical as a medium for representing and translating St Lucian culture and history for foreign readers, but wrestles with the cultural politics implied by this act of classical reception as the classical allusions threaten to displace St Lucia and to reinforce the cultural subordination that it suffered under British colonial rule. In terms of the politics of classical reception, it is not an exaggeration to describe Walcott's reception of ancient Greek epic in *Omeros* as an experiment in subaltern classics as he tests whether or not Homeric epic (and Virgil, and Dante, and Joyce, and Pound—to name some of the other prominent 'classical' literary influences in the poem) can viably represent the history and culture of St Lucia without belittling it.

That this is not a conventional encounter with the august classics is signalled by the title, which routes Homer through the modern Greek name for Homer, inflected with a St Lucian patois etymology. In homage to the people and culture of St Lucia, the poem begins with the island's fishermen and the opening line, delivered by the character Philoctete, is spoken in Caribbean English ('This is how, one sunrise, we cut down them canoes').³⁵ Also in the first chapter the ordinariness of Walcott's Omeric world is underscored by a detail of Achilles relieving himself: 'Achille peed in the dark, then bolted the half-door shut.'³⁶ This is Homeric adaptation in the modernist tradition of Joyce's *Ulysses*, in which the quotidian ordinariness of the characters' lives exercises a strong anti-epic and anti-classical critique. In chapter 3 when we first encounter the Homeric sounding protagonists Achilles and Hector together, they are trading insults in patois over a bailing tin that Achilles has borrowed from Hector's canoe.³⁷ As the poet-narrator describes the scene where he begins to reimagine Homeric epic in the context of his island, he heard 'the prose | of abrupt fishermen cursing over canoes'.³⁸ Achilles is a subsistence fisherman and Hector is a fisherman turned transport-driver (a 'road-warrior' in recognition of the Homeric pedigree of his



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name).³⁹ The Helen over whom they quarrel is variously a housemaid, a waitress, and a casual worker in a beach kiosk, plaiting tourists' hair.

Although the coincidence of their Homeric names provides a point of entry for foreign readers, readers are constantly reminded not to project Homeric expectations onto the characters' lives through a narrative strategy of misrecognition. As the poem proceeds, almost every analogy, simile, and allusion connecting St Lucia to Homer is swiftly negated or problematized, with the effect that Achilles, Hector, and Helen are defined by their difference from Homeric heroes as much as by their similarity.⁴⁰ This trope is familiar from Walcott's earlier poetry, epitomized by the last three lines of the poem 'Gros-llet' (from *The Arkansas Testament*);

This is not the grape-purple Aegean.
There is no wine here, no cheese, the almonds are green,
the sea grapes bitter, the language is that of slaves.⁴¹

This constant correction of expectations is reinforced by explicit, metapoetic narratorial interventions in which the poet-narrator comments on the folly and misrepresentation that looking for Homeric parallels entails.⁴² The classical is a hook for one significant interpretative community who form a large part of the projected readership of the poem,⁴³ but readers are then required to see past the classical figures to the St Lucian themes that they represent. The classical is a vehicle for translation and what it translates, imperfectly and controversially, is a subaltern world from the perspective of many of the poem's highly literate, elite readers and of the poet himself.

The most explicit realization of a subaltern poetics in the poem is the scene in which the ghost of Warwick Walcott, the poet-narrator's father, prescribes a native poetics for Walcott based on the rhythm of the bare feet of the women who used to act as coal-porters for the ships in Castries harbour. Prior to this, Warwick has described their mutual home—Castries—as 'this obscure Caribbean port', alluded to the poetic pedigree of his name, Warwick, birthplace of Shakespeare ('the Bard's county'), and recounted his sense of alienation from 'the foreign machinery known as literature'.⁴⁴ In reaction against this foreign machinery, Warwick advocates a subaltern poetics modelled on and inspired by the work of coal-carrying women, whom the young Derek Walcott watched from a window in their house. Lance Callahan has analysed the intricacies of the metrical scheme in *Omeros* and sketched the contours of the metrical contract that Walcott develops with his readers.⁴⁵ But the metrical contract coexists with an ideological poetic contract, expressed in terms of a debt and a duty to the

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dispossessed women from whom the poet-narrator has inherited his ‘ancestral rhyme’:

keep to that narrow causeway without looking down,
 climbing in their footsteps, that slow, ancestral beat
 of those used to climbing roads; your own work owes them

 because the couplet of those multiplying feet
 made your first rhymes.⁴⁶

Warwick gives an alternative, native aetiology for the metrical feet of *Omeros* and its rhyme scheme, explaining how a poem can be at once classical and subaltern as the poem keeps pace with local life and work (‘they walk, you write’).⁴⁷ These women occupy a subaltern position not just in economic terms and in terms of their gender, but also in political, historical, and cultural terms because they have no means of self-representation. ‘Look, they climb, and no one knows them; | ... and your duty ... | [two lines omitted] is the chance you now have, to give those feet a voice’ (I.XIII.iii; p. 75). While some readers have found this notion of a barefoot poetics premised on the hard labour of the coal porters objectionable for its artistic exploitation of subsistence work (indeed Walcott invites this very objection—see below), it is hard to doubt the sincerity of Walcott’s striving to represent all St Lucia in this high literary work, as indicated by the increased privileging of St Lucian Kweyol and St Lucian English Creole across successive drafts, particularly at the very beginning of the poem.⁴⁸

The poem dramatizes the politics of its own poetics: can a high literary work of great metrical complexity and dense literary allusivity, modelled on classical foreign literatures, tell the story of everyday St Lucians the majority of whom lack any advanced education? The poet-narrator’s consciousness is divided, as he merges in and out of the first person plural—claiming community with his St Lucian characters—and the third person plural as he recognizes his alienation from their world. The same narrative voice asks, ‘Who will teach us a history of which we too are capable?’,⁴⁹ numbering himself as part of a broader St Lucian community and, conversely, worries about his artistic exploitation objectification of the St Lucian poor: ‘Hadn’t I made their poverty my paradise?’⁵⁰

In *Omeros* Walcott confronts the tensions and contradictions at the heart of subaltern classics. The poem worries over its prerogative in narrating the lives of the illiterate poor, but it also strives for an inclusive construction of St Lucian identity in which all St Lucians are represented, regardless of their race, class, education, or colonial history (ex-colonized or ex-colonizer). The poet-narrator predicts that the poem will miss many of those from whom it draws inspiration—fishermen like

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Achille and Hector, and waitresses and domestic workers like Helen. It is an epic for the people, in full consciousness of the fact that these same people will not read it. Referring to the character Achille, the poet-narrator reflects on the gulf between the humble life of the character and the literary world of the book in which he features, ‘this book, which will remain unknown | and unread by him’.⁵¹ Prior to this, at the burial service for Maud Plunkett the poet-narrator wonders, somewhat condescendingly, *over* Achille’s presence given that he cannot follow the xeroxed order of service: ‘Why should he be here, why should they have come at all, | none of them following the words, ...’⁵² This is arguably the most insistent contradiction at the heart of the conceit of subaltern classics: when, in the service of representing the subaltern, an author expounds a vernacular classical culture only to run up against the *vernacular* gap between their art and those whom they would represent.

Ovidian experiments with subaltern speech: Marlene Nourbese Philip’s *She Tries her Tongue, her Silence Softly Breaks* (1989)

The poet-narrator in Walcott worries over the politics of Homeric analogies in the context of St Lucia, and exposes the dubious patriarchal impulse to describe and narrate Helen in terms of her Homeric namesake. Plunkett’s fantasy of providing Helen with a history is doomed from the start, framed in terms of ‘historic hallucination’ and ‘mythical hallucination’:⁵³

Helen needed a history,
That was the pity that Plunkett felt towards her.
Not his, but her story. Not theirs, but Helen’s war.⁵⁴

For his part, the poet-narrator does not do much better: ‘the name Helen had gripped my wrist in its vise | to plunge it into the foaming page.’⁵⁵ The question of what Helen’s story might consist of, *qua* black Caribbean woman, is tackled in a collection by Marlene Nourbese Philip, published the year before *Omeros*.⁵⁶ This is a work that offers a radically different version of subaltern classics in which the classical has none of the cultural prestige and presumptive hegemony that it has in *Omeros*. Instead, the classical is part of a ransacked cultural archive, which the poet turns inside out in pursuit of a radical black feminist poetics. In Nourbese Philip’s hands, classics become a source of usable myths and fragments and, as such, its value is in its ability to transcend historical time. Maria Christina Fumagalli has identified a radical critique of north Atlantic structures of knowledge in Philip’s use of classical myth, arguing that the achronicity of

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classical myth makes the New and Old World coeval and ‘explodes the notion of progress, one of the central tenets of north Atlantic modernity’.⁵⁷

In *She Tries her Tongue, her Silence Softly Breaks* (henceforth *She Tries her Tongue*), Philip contends that the story of the black Caribbean woman needs a new language and a new poetics. In the manifesto ‘The Absence of Writing or How I Almost Became a Spy’, which functions as an introduction to *She Tries her Tongue*, Philip aligns herself with the black female subjects of the poems in this collection in an affirmation of a subaltern poetics that aims to represent a group that has been denied a literary voice:

For the many like me, black and female, it is imperative that our writing begin to recreate our histories and our myths, as well as integrate that most painful of experiences—loss of our history and our word.⁵⁸

More fundamentally, Nourbese Philip sketches how the enforced migration of Africans to the Caribbean, their enslavement, and their alienation from their native cultures and languages, has led to the loss of language. Concurrent with the institutionalized rape on slave plantations, this amounts to a rape of the mother and the rape of their original language (figured as a ‘mother’ tongue), leaving black women Caribbean writers in the anglophone Caribbean with an English, ‘father’ tongue over which they have no proprietary claims. Philip evokes the striking image of linguistic squatting: ‘For too long, however, we have been verbal or linguistic squatters, possessing adversely what is truly ours.’⁵⁹

Philip has recourse to Ovid’s *Metamorphoses* in order to convey the dynamics of the historical situation of the black woman writer in the Caribbean and the changes in conventional poetry that are necessary in order to represent the (violent) changes that went into the making of her situation. In the foreground of her narrative, Philip adapts Ovid’s versions of the rapes of Io, Proserpina, and Philomela to represent the actual and symbolic rape of the black woman and her culture:

The stories of Io, Philomela, Ceres, and Proserpina interest Philip because they echo the predicament of the many female slaves raped by their white masters and because they resonate with the experiences of the African slaves in the New World who, deprived of their mother tongues, had to find a new language to express themselves.⁶⁰

At one level it is possible to read Philip’s cooptation of Ovid into her narrative as a classical symptom of the problem, inviting readers to ponder the connection between this classic text that has fertilized so much literary and artistic endeavour in the West and which teems with rapes,⁶¹ and the rapacity of European colonial powers in the Middle Passage and in their New World colonies. However, this logic

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is left implicit. Instead, for Philip, just as important as the mythical rapes of the *Metamorphoses*, which symbolize the history of plantation rape in the Caribbean, is the metaliterary potential of metamorphosis, which in Ovid acts as a consummate translation project encompassing material transformation (changed bodies), adaptation, translation, transliteration, and other forms of word play.⁶² If the middle passage resulted in ‘The linguistic rape and subsequent forced marriage between African and English tongues’,⁶³ then the proper representation of the black Caribbean woman’s experience in English literature will revolve around the theme of metamorphosis: how two bodies created one and how two cultures and languages created one that bears internal traces of their difference: ‘While I continue to write in my father tongue, I continue to engender by some alchemical practice a metamorphosis within the language from father to mother tongue.’⁶⁴

The challenge that Philip pursues throughout the collection is to interweave the ‘standard’ English language and the Caribbean demotic of English in such a way that the language that results is both mother and father tongue,⁶⁵ and to use it to narrate subject matter that is expressive of the complex, diverse, and divided yet coherent cultural inheritance of the black woman writer in the modern Caribbean. The stakes are high: to recover from the metaphorical silence of writing within a language that is not expressive of one’s identity or experience (Philip mobilizes the Rastafarian idiolect in the concept of the i-mage):

The paradox at the heart of the acquisition of this language is that the African learned both to speak and to be dumb at the same time, to give voice to the experience and i-mage, yet remain silent.⁶⁶

The first poem in the collection ‘And Over Every Land and Sea’ narrates the gist of Ceres’ frantic search for her daughter Proserpina, translated into contemporary idiom. While Ceres searches, Proserpina tries to trace her mother (or ‘a mother’) through an adoption bureau: ‘She whom they call mother, I seek.’⁶⁷ In Philip’s poem the alienation of daughter from mother is not just physical and geographical, but cultural and linguistic as well:

A four-day night of walk bring me
to where never see she:
is ‘come child, come,’ and ‘welcome’ I looking—
the how in lost between She
and I, call and response in tongue and
word that buck up in strange; . . .⁶⁸

If Ovid’s *Metamorphoses* gives Philip a mythical analogue for the lost child and for rape (in the sense of both ravishment and abduction), it also points towards a redress

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at the level of linguistic subversion. The focus on lost language and displacement within a language intensifies as the collection progresses. The poem ‘Meditations on the Declension of Beauty by the Girl with the Flying Cheek-bones’ contains the refrain, ‘If not in yours | in whose language | Am I.’⁶⁹ In order for Proserpina to find her mother, she will need to change her language and to change her imagery. In the previous poem the existing regime of history and memory is undercut through word play, as mute evolves into museum in an argument from etymology:⁷⁰

mute
 muse
 museums

Elsewhere Ovidian word play repeatedly helps the narrator out of the impasse of silence, as in ‘Discourse on the Logic of Language’:⁷¹

I must therefore be tongue
 dumb
 dumb-tongued
 dub-tongued
 damn dumb
 tongue

The incidence of dub in this passage is significant for modelling classical reception in Philip’s work. Evelyn O’Callaghan has pointed to the significance of dub as a metaphor for the way in which Caribbean women writers adapt, innovate upon, and subvert existing traditions.⁷² But this process of linguistic metamorphosis is not without pain; in the same poem ‘English as a foreign language’ is parsed as ‘a foreign l/anguish | anguish | a foreign anguish’, and seen through the colonial prism of standard English, Caribbean demotic is ‘this lingua franca | arrrrrrrrgot of a blasted soul’.⁷³ The pain is where Philomela comes in, raped by her brother-in-law and subsequently ‘silenced’ by him by having her tongue mutilated; but it is Philomela’s song, figured as ‘pure utterance’ that offers the final hope for the realization of Philip’s project:⁷⁴

... Silence
 Song word speech
 Might I... like Philomela... sing
 continue
 over
 into
 ... pure utterance



*Subaltern Classics in English*The democratic potential of classical reception: Toni Morrison's *Beloved* (1987)

For Toni Morrison, classical myth has currency not because of the elite cultural prestige that it represents, but because of the translatability of the subject matter and the form, which allows it to communicate, in different ways, with different local traditions.⁷⁵ In the case of Morrison's novel *Beloved* (1987), classical myth complements the local history and myth that surrounded the historical slave Margaret Garner, nicknamed 'the modern Medea'.⁷⁶

Sethe, the protagonist of *Beloved*, is ostensibly triply subaltern: a former slave who enjoys precarious freedom in the North (Cincinnati), and a black woman in a racist and misogynist society.⁷⁷ Moreover, even within her local 'free negro' community she is an outcast, reputed to be crazy, as a result of her infanticide of her daughter, Beloved. The narrator captures her abject status in the eyes of the community with the graphic, passive past participle 'junkheaped':

Anybody feeling sorry for her, anybody wandering by to peep in and see how she was getting on (including Paul D) would discover that the woman junkheaped for the third time because she loved her children—that woman was sailing happily on a frozen creek.⁷⁸

The resistance that Morrison offers to a passive, tragic narrative of enslavement and its horrors is to record the horrors but to insist on the resilience of Sethe and on her capacity for life in spite of the 'living death' of her life as a slave. Sethe is a tragic protagonist in the mould of Euripides' *Medea*—cast out and cast down but not defeated. While the identification of Sethe with Medea has a proximate source in the American abolitionist tradition,⁷⁹ the fact that the primary classical source centres around a non-Greek woman who challenges and offends Greek cultural norms makes it especially conducive for Morrison's adaptation.⁸⁰

As with the other works examined in this chapter, Morrison's aesthetic project is also deeply preoccupied with the ethics, politics, and poetics of literary and historical representation and the presence and absence of subaltern characters who did not control the means and rights of representation. The main characters in *Beloved* correspond to the most dispossessed of Gramsci's subaltern groups—those who have no political organization and representation—and to Spivak's conception of the subaltern subject who, represented in official narratives that silence her, 'cannot speak'. In fact, the eponymous character Beloved, the murdered child, is the most dispossessed of all; in her Foreword to the novel Morrison describes Beloved as 'the one who lost everything and had no say in

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any of it'.⁸¹ The institution of chattel slavery in the American South used denial of self-representation as one of its technologies of suppression and control, including the right to rename the slaves, the systematic alienation of slaves from their native languages and cultures, and the denial of literacy to slaves—all of which feature prominently in *Beloved*.⁸² Most sinister of all was the bit—a dehumanizing instrument of correction and punishment designed to prevent slaves from speaking. Commenting on its presence in *Beloved*, Morrison has described this instrument as 'the signal instrument of silence' in the novel, and the 'complete erasure of all language that the victim or the oppressed had'.⁸³ The Schoolteacher, Mr Garner's brother-in-law, who takes over as overseer after Mr Garner dies, explicitly observes and records the slaves as a prejudicial ethnographer with ink prepared for him via Sethe:

A pretty good farmer, Halle said. Not strong as Mr. Garner but smart enough. He liked the ink I made. It was her recipe, but he preferred how I mixed it and it was important to him because at night he sat down to write in his book. It was a book about us but we didn't know that right away. We just thought it was his manner to ask us questions. He commenced to carry round a notebook and write down what we said.⁸⁴

The slaves unwittingly furnish the materials and the subject for a book over whose strategies of representation they have no control. When Stamp Paid shows Paul D a newspaper clipping with the news of Sethe's infanticide, before he has read the news Paul D knows that its content will invariably be negative according to the racialized politics of representation: 'Because there was no way in hell a black face could appear in a newspaper if the story was about something anybody wanted to hear.'⁸⁵

Judylyn Ryan has analysed the ethical and spiritual project that informs Morrison's fiction and criticism in terms of a 'democracy of narrative participation', which she describes as a narrative technique that 'enables the artist to expand the narrative to reveal that even individuals whose presence is temporally or socially limited have full personalities and unlimited human agency'.⁸⁶ Connecting this to Morrison's classical receptions, we could also evoke Ellison's figure of 'the little man behind the stove' at Chehaw Station, who 'democratically innocent of hierarchical striving, . . . takes his classics as he takes his tall tales or jazz—without frills'.⁸⁷ We can see Morrison's engagement with Euripides in terms of this expansive, democratic participation in the interpretation of the Greek and Roman classics, which have been received by modern American culture. Euripides' version of the Medea myth supplies Morrison with a complex,

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ethical source that confounds facile antinomies and forces an attempt to try to understand the position of the historical Margaret Garner through the character of Sethe.⁸⁸

In keeping with the ‘democracy of narrative participation’, Morrison is sensitive to the dangers of laying proprietary claims to Greek tragedy, in the way that past European and American classical traditions have sometimes done. Instead, the dialogue between Morrison’s fictional reimagining of history, the historical record about Margaret Garner, and Euripides’ play forces an opening up of the classical tradition to accommodate additional cultural resonances rather than excluding those which the myth has already gained. *Beloved*’s oblique engagement with Euripides’ *Medea*, among other myths and sources, presents readers with the realization that Margaret Garner’s story is germane to Euripides’ play and that the play acquires a potent set of meanings in light of the American experience of slavery. There is a profound sense of historical and cultural leveling in Morrison’s classical reception as she recognizes and co-opts elements of Greek tragedy because they are familiar, not because they are ‘classical’, insisting on the power of the form not the ‘civilization’ behind it. Just as importantly, and this too is part of the ‘democracy of narrative participation’, Morrison’s homing into Greek tragedy does not preclude or negate other receptions of Greek tragedy, which will find other cultural aspects of the plays germane and familiar. As Morrison stated in the essay ‘Unspeakable Things Unspoken’:⁸⁹

A large part of the satisfaction I have always received from reading Greek tragedy, for example, is in its similarity to Afro-American communal structures (the function of song and chorus, the heroic struggle between the chorus of community and individual hubris) and African religion and philosophy. In other words, that is part of the reason it has quality for me—I feel intellectually at home there. But that could hardly be so for those unfamiliar with my ‘home,’ and hardly a requisite for the pleasure they take. The point is, the form (Greek tragedy) makes available these varieties of provocative love because *it* is masterly—not because the civilization that is its referent was flawless or superior to all others. [my underlining]⁹⁰

However, this insistence on the openness of Greek tragedy, the trans-cultural mobility and translatability of the form, and the rejection of the idea that ancient Greek civilization was superior constitutes an indirect rebuke to the proprietorial fashioning of Greek and Roman classics in an exclusively white American image associated with the culture of the pre-bellum American South. Here I am persuaded by Tessa Roynon’s interpretation of the relationship between *Beloved* and the historiography of the American Civil War, in which she argues that

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Beloved uses Greek myth to challenge and undo the classicizing mythical structures that supported the narrative about the Old South and the ‘tragedy’ of its defeat in the Civil War: ‘To insist, therefore, as Morrison does with *Beloved*, that the tragedy and tragic heroism in these events belongs not to the Confederacy but to African Americans is to challenge the erasure of political realities that became the dominant cultural norm.’⁹¹ While Morrison opens up the cultural referentiality of Greek tragedy, the ethical force of her interpretation challenges readers to differentiate between conflicting receptions of Greek and Roman classics.

In this case, to mobilize an ethical reading is not to moralize on one side or the other, but instead to dramatize the sphere of action within which Sethe (and Margaret Garner) could have done what she did: to make her a purposeful, rational agent in an historical context where men and women like her ‘were moved around like checkers’.⁹² When challenged about the morality of her actions, Sethe asserts the coherence of her logic in acting to protect her children from a greater evil: ‘It ain’t my job to know what’s worse. It’s my job to know what is and to keep them away from what I know is terrible. I did that.’⁹³ Subsequently, in the interpretation of Sethe’s action that Stamp Paid gives, we can recognize the rationale of Euripides’ Medea: ‘She ain’t crazy. She love those children. She was trying to out-hurt the hurter.’⁹⁴ The classical model supplies a precedent and a context for the representation of the subaltern in mainstream, universal discourse. In fact, rather than a precedent in the legal sense, the classical inter-text supplies a pretext in the sense of both an argument for and a textual forerunner to open up a space in which a fictional subaltern character can speak.

Classical complementarity: epic song culture and communal song in Rita Dove’s *Mother Love* (1995)

At one level it is possible to read Rita Dove’s adaptation of the Demeter and Persephone myth in the 1995 collection *Mother Love* as responding, on and in its own terms, to the boldness of Morrison’s engagement with Greek myth in *Beloved*.⁹⁵ Whatever else the Demeter–Persephone myth signifies in contemporary America,⁹⁶ and alongside her shrewd analysis of the psychology of the mother–daughter relationship, for Dove this myth also signifies the involuntary alienation of mother and daughter experienced by African Americans in modern



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American history, of which Morrison's Sethe is a prominent fictional icon. Sethe as Margaret Garner springs to mind in the poem 'Persephone Abducted', with its resolute statement of the logic of motherhood:⁹⁷

No one can tell a mother how to act:
there are no laws when laws are broken, no names
to call upon.

Dove has commented on the historical fragility of the African American family and the consequent strength of family bonds in an interview with Wayne Ude conducted in 1992: 'The whole obsession with family is rooted in the essential African American trauma . . . when you not only didn't know whether you could keep a family together, but you were practically guaranteed that you couldn't.'⁹⁸ Dove's keen sense of the family as a cultural institution and the cultural specificity of motherhood simultaneously recommends the Demeter and Persephone myth and determines its translatability within the target culture. Consequently, *Mother Love* breaks the mythical frame at regular intervals to signal the historical and contemporary tragedy of child abduction and molestation. In 'Political', 'Even Demeter keeps digging | towards that darkest miracle, | the hope of finding her child unmolested';⁹⁹ in 'Grief: The Council', the narrator alludes to the NCMEC campaign to raise awareness about missing children, 'I thought of those blurred snapshots framed | on milk cartons, a new pair each week',¹⁰⁰ and in 'Missing' the Persephone figure narrates her own disappearance echoing the language of police reports ('last | known whereabouts') and observing, 'A lost | child is a fact hardening around its absence.'¹⁰¹

As with Morrison's merging of the aesthetic and the ethical, an important part of Dove's poetic experiment with the sonnet form and the personal, lyric voice in this collection is her exploration of the relationship between individual and community that gives broader social meaning to the individual self. The community in this poem is culturally and historically constituted and unmistakably African American. While the formal model for the poet's lyric experiment is Rilke's *Sonnets to Orpheus*, as signalled in the Foreword ('An Intact World'), the poet-narrator's voice derives its cultural resonance and impact from communal song structures in the African American tradition. In the poem 'Persephone Abducted', the narrator remarks that 'she left us singing in the field' (p. 13), and in 'Political' there is another reference to communal song, this time lamentation mistaken for song 'our wail starts up | of its own accord, is mistaken for song', which evokes the tradition of Blues.¹⁰² The obvious thematic analogies with the blues are also the subject of self-referential humour in the poems 'Golden Oldie'

and ‘Rusks’.¹⁰³ In the former, the narrator’s train of thought is arrested by the ‘golden oldie’—the Supremes’ ‘Where Did Our Love Go?’ (1964)—on the car radio: ‘swaying | at the wheel like a blind pianist caught in a tune | meant for more than two hands playing’ . . . ‘*Baby, where did our love go?*—a lament | I greedily took in’, and in the latter the narrator quips, ‘I got tired of tearing myself down. | Let someone else have | the throne of blues for a while.’ These several instances plug Dove’s collection into what Houston Baker has described as the cultural synthesis that is ‘the blues matrix’, inflecting classical myth (derived in this instance from archaic Greek song culture—*The Homeric Hymn to Demeter*) with vernacular song culture.¹⁰⁴ At a structural level, the division of the collection between mother (Demeter) and daughter (Persephone) and the tension between them could also be viewed in terms of antagonistic collaboration, all the more so because in places it is impossible to distinguish between the two, since the mother is herself a daughter and the daughter a potential mother. Indeed, this antagonistic collaboration is figured formally in certain poems (e.g. poem VII of ‘Persephone in Hell’, and ‘The Bistro Styx’), by means of antiphonal typographical arrangement in the former and back-and-forth repartee in the latter.¹⁰⁵

Dove is clear that her recourse to Greek myth is grounded in convenience: these stories fit and resonate with her experience and that of her readers, but there is no idolization or elevation of the classical for its own sake.¹⁰⁶ As Dove commented in an interview with Steven Bellin in 1995, myth is a convenient shortcut for helping to identify vital themes, likening it to taking a break to take out the trash when the creative writing process is flagging: ‘Myth, in an interesting way, can function in the same way as taking out the trash. By following the trajectory of a myth, by reimagining its principal characters or exploring a tangent, one can stumble upon the crucial stuff—what one really thinks and feels.’¹⁰⁷

Greek and Roman classics have a place in Dove’s collection because many of the themes that they explore resonate with the African American archive and because they are germane to an American aesthetic that is an amalgam of different styles and traditions.¹⁰⁸ The black vernacular tradition and historical experience is woven subtly through the poem: the narrator of ‘Persephone Abducted’, one of a community of black women who comment, chorus-like, on the action, alludes to the aching labour of the cottonfields (whether on the slave plantation or as oppressed sharecroppers), remarking that Persephone ‘left us singing in the field, oblivious | to all but the ache of our own bent backs’.¹⁰⁹ The rhythms of African American vernacular culture resound through the first two sections of *Mother Love*, and intertwine with the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*, with Rilke’s

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Sonnets to Orpheus, and with the copious other literary allusions in Dove's collection.¹¹⁰ *Mother Love* manipulates several classical traditions simultaneously and requires suppleness of the reader in moving between cultures and in embracing a complex whole.

The complementarity between classical and vernacular cultures is evident in the title poem 'Mother Love'. This poem gives us, if not Ellison's little man behind the stove, then Demeter in disguise as a nursemaid at the hearth, giving Demophoön his nightly fire treatment, as narrated in the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*.¹¹¹ The narration is ostensibly straight: the narrator is plausibly Demeter, with a sassy homily about the innate reflexes of motherhood, even more so when she recounts her experience caring for Metaneira's son. But there are no names in the poem, which makes it infinitely adaptable to the American target culture. And within a North American context, in a collection authored by a black American woman poet,¹¹² Demeter's story takes on new meaning. It is hard not to see Demeter's situation in this poem—at a stove looking after another woman's child—through the lens of the black nurse nursing another woman's children (the 'mammy' figure), while her own children have been taken from her, as Persephone has been taken from Demeter. Aside from the vernacular rhythms of the poem, which belong to a recognizably American tradition, the only explicit American reference comes in the penultimate line with its simile comparing the baby bathed in fire to a Virginia ham:

Each night
I laid him on the smoldering embers,
sealing his juices in slowly so he might
be cured to perfection. Oh, I know it
looked damning: at the hearth a muttered crone
bent over a baby sizzling on a spit
as neat as a Virginia ham.¹¹³

This bathetic and irreverent turn¹¹⁴ is a wonderful instance of the capacity that Ellison attributed to the vernacular muse—the little man at Chehaw Station—who confounds 'hierarchical expectations', has an instinct for 'cultural incongruity', and is able to 'temper the chilliest of classics to his own vernacular taste'.¹¹⁵ But the fiction is restored in the very last line of the poem as Demeter stays in character as a goddess, 'Poor human— | to scream like that, to make me remember.'

Demeter as goddess in disguise as nursemaid is at once ultra-classical and subaltern, doubly so in Dove's version of this section of the hymn where the figure of the African American nursemaid, both before and after emancipation, is

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brought to mind. This classical ambivalence, where the classical repeatedly collides and blurs with the vernacular, is encapsulated in the last sentence of Dove's Foreword:

The Demeter/Persephone cycle of betrayal and regeneration is ideally suited for this form since all three—mother-goddess, daughter-consort and poet—are struggling to sing in their chains.

Singing in chains reiterates the trope of the sonnet's paradoxically enabling formal constraints and evokes the role that slavery played in the formation of mainstream African American musical and poetic genres. Here too, Demeter and Persephone are both classical and vernacular.

Conclusion

'subaltern classics' is just one mode of engagement with Greek and Roman classics in contemporary literature and one that, for obvious reasons, is particularly pronounced in post- and anti-colonial literatures. All of the different classical receptions discussed in this chapter are something of an experiment in subaltern classics. By its very nature, an endeavour that uses classical texts to represent subaltern communities will invariably reveal a gap between the classical accretions that have clustered around Greek and Roman myths and literature, the target readership addressed, and the subaltern group(s) represented. But in mediating this gap, and in trying to triangulate all three, Malouf, Walcott, Philip, Morrison, and Dove show the *suppleness* of Greek and Roman classics in mediating, cutting across, and outwitting the classical tradition of English literature.

Notes

¹ Simon Gikandi *Maps of Englishness: Writing Identity and the Culture of Colonialism* (New York, 1996), p. xi: colonialism 'was not something one associated with the culture of Great Britain or with its monumental literary works. Indeed, when it came to the organization of knowledge and literary culture, the common practice was to separate the Great Tradition of English literature from the new body of writing that had been produced in the former colonies.' In particular, Gikandi cites the influence of Leavis's concept of 'The Great Tradition' of the English novel: *ibid.*, p. xvii and p. 234 with n. 20.

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² Robert Crawford, *Devolving English Literature*, 2nd rev. edn (Edinburgh, 2000), p. 7 (first published in 1992).

³ The Comment ‘On the Abolition of the English Department’ was circulated on 24 October 1968, co-signed by James Ngugi, Henry Owuor-Anyumba, and Tabah Lo Liyong. It was a response to a paper presented by the Acting Head of the English Department at the University of Nairobi at the 42nd meeting of the Arts Faculty Board on 20 September 1968. The paper is included as an Appendix to Ngugi wa Thiong’o, *Homecoming: Essays on African and Caribbean Literature, Culture, and Politics* (New York, 1973).

⁴ Heaney was a citizen of Northern Ireland and objected to being identified with Britain to the exclusion of Ireland; see the note on the first stanza in Seamus Heaney, *An Open Letter*. A Field Day Pamphlet, Number 2 (Derry, 1983), p. 14.

⁵ Heaney, *An Open Letter*, p. 13.

⁶ See Marlene Nourbese Philip, *She Tries her Tongue, her Silence Softly Breaks* (Charlottetown, 1989), p. 22: ‘The manuscript, *She Tries her Tongue*, has taken me a long way towards the goal of decentering the language. This is not the same thing as destroying a language which is a far harder thing to do.’ On the ‘anguish’ of the English language in Philip, see ‘Ovidian experiments with subaltern speech’ below.

⁷ Important anglophone book-length studies of imperial (and counter-imperial), post-colonial, and black diasporic classical receptions include: *Classics & Colonialism*, ed. Barbara Goff (London, 2005); Patrice Rankine, *Ulysses in Black: Ralph Ellison, Classicism, and African American Literature* (Madison, 2006); *Classics in Post-Colonial Worlds*, ed. Lorna Hardwick and Carol Gillespie (Oxford, 2007); Barbara Goff and Michael Simpson, *Crossroads in the Black Aegean: Odysseus, Antigone, and Dramas of the African Diaspora* (Oxford, 2008); Emily Greenwood *Afro-Greeks: Dialogues Between Anglophone Caribbean Literature and Classics in the Twentieth Century* (Oxford, 2010); Michael Lambert *The Classics and South African Identities* (London, 2010); *Classics and Imperialism in the British Empire*, ed. Mark Bradley (Oxford, 2010); *Classics and National Cultures*, ed. Susan Stephens and Phiroze Vasunia (Oxford, 2010); *African Athena: New Agendas*, ed. Daniel Orrells, Gurminder K. Bhambra, and Tessa Roynon (Oxford, 2011); Barbara Goff, ‘Your Secret Language’: *Classics in the British Colonies of West Africa* (London, 2013); Justine McConnell, *Black Odysseys: The Homeric Odyssey in the African Diaspora since 1939* (Oxford, 2013); and Phiroze Vasunia, *The Classics and Colonial India* (Oxford, 2013).

⁸ For a good overview of the arguments pro and contra, see Christine Macleod ‘Black American Literature and the Postcolonial Debate’, *The Yearbook of English Studies* 27 (1997), 51–65. See also John Cullen Gruesser, *Confluences: Postcolonialism, African American Literary Studies, and the Black Atlantic* (Athens, Ga, 2007).

⁹ Several of the works cited in n. 7 above examine intersecting, anti-and post-colonial classical receptions in different national and transnational traditions, including African nations and modern India. There is a growing body of scholarship on classical receptions in anglophone African literatures. Studies of anti- and post-colonial classical receptions in Africa have focused predominantly on West Africa (especially Nigeria and Ghana) and South Africa. For South Africa, see Michael Lambert, *The Classics and South African Identities* (London, 2010), and

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South Africa, Greece, Rome, ed. Grant Parker (Cambridge, 2017). For West Africa see Barbara Goff, 'Your Secret Language': *Classics in the British Colonies of West Africa* (London, 2013). There has been particular emphasis on the reception of classical Greek tragedy in South Africa and West Africa; on which see Kevin J. Wetmore, Jr, *The Athenian Sun in an African Sky: Modern African Adaptations of Classical Greek Tragedy* (Jefferson, NC, 2002), and Barbara Goff and Michael Simpson, *Crossroads in the Black Aegean: Odysseus, Antigone, and Dramas of the African Diaspora* (Oxford, 2008). Additional studies on African classical receptions can be found in *Alma Parens Originalis? The Receptions of Classical Literature and Thought in Africa, Europe, the United States, and Cuba*, ed. J. Hilton and A. Gosling (Frankfurt am Main, 2007), pp. 42–175, and in *Classics in Post-Colonial Worlds*, ed. Lorna Hardwick and Carol Gillespie (Oxford, 2007).

¹⁰ For Gramsci's various writings on the subaltern and the development of his thinking about the subaltern, see Marcus Green, 'Gramsci Cannot Speak: Presentations and Interpretations of Gramsci's Concept of the Subaltern', *Rethinking Marxism: A Journal of Economics, Culture & Society* 14:3 (2002), 1–24. Green's discussion includes a critique of Spivak's interpretation of the subaltern. Spivak's essay was first delivered as a lecture in 1983, published in 1988, and published in a revised version in 1999. Both versions are conveniently reprinted in *Can the Subaltern Speak? Reflections on the History of an Idea*, ed. Rosalind C. Morris (New York, 2010), pp. 21–78 (the 1999 version), and pp. 237–91 (the 1988 version).

¹¹ On access to representation, see Gramsci Notebook 14 § 39, cited in n. 27.

¹² See James Porter, 'Introduction: What is "Classical" about Classical Antiquity', in *The Classical Traditions of Greece and Rome*, ed. James I. Porter (Princeton, 2006), pp. 1–65 (especially p. 9). Porter's introduction offers an excellent discussion of the post-classical invention of the idea of the classics, and the classical.

¹³ A term coined by Arjun Appadurai, 'Disjuncture and Difference in the Global Cultural Economy', *Public Culture* 2:2 (Spring 1990), 1–24 (p. 3). The context in Appadurai's article is the uncanny transplantation of nostalgic American pop music in the Philippines without any of the chronology or cultural referentiality to support the nostalgia; Appadurai describes this transplantation as 'playing havoc with Eurochronology'.

¹⁴ See Emily Greenwood, *Afro-Greeks: Dialogues Between Anglophone Caribbean Literature and Classics in the Twentieth Century* (Oxford, 2010), chapter 3, for an example of the critique of these imperial classical fictions in anglophone Caribbean literature.

¹⁵ Derek Walcott, *Omeros* (New York, 1990), 7.LVIII; pp. 289–94.

¹⁶ Houston A. Baker, Jr, *Blues, Ideology, and Afro-American Literature: A Vernacular Theory* (Chicago, 1984), p. 2.

¹⁷ David Malouf, *Ransom* (New York, 2009). In Book 1 of Virgil's *Aeneid* (1.487) this scene features ecphrastically as one of the paradigmatic scenes of the Trojan War depicted on a frieze in the temple of Juno in Carthage.

¹⁸ *Iliad* 24.162–5.

¹⁹ Ps. Apollodorus 2.6.4 (trans. Frazer 1921): 'when he [Hercules] had taken the city and shot down Laomedon and his sons, except Podarces, he assigned Laomedon's daughter Hesione as a prize to Telamon and allowed her to take with her whomsoever of the captives she would.'



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When she chose her brother Podarces, Hercules said that he must first be a slave and then be ransomed by her. So when he was being sold she took the veil from her head and gave it as a ransom, hence Podarces was called Priam.’ Malouf gives the outline of this tale in his Afterword (*Ransom*, p. 223).

²⁰ Malouf, *Ransom*, pp. 62–75, quoting from pp. 68–9.

²¹ Malouf, *Ransom*, pp. 184–5: [Priam to Achilles] ‘Would your father, Peleus, not do the same for you? Strip himself of all the ornaments of power, and with no concern any longer for pride or distinction, do what is most human—come as I do, a plain man white-haired and old, and entreat the killer of his son, with whatever small dignity is left him, to remember his own death, and the death of his father, and do as these things are honourably done among us, to take the ransom I bring and give me back my son.’

²² Malouf, *Ransom*, p. 97.

²³ Quoting from Malouf, *Ransom*, pp. 93 and 179 respectively.

²⁴ Malouf, *Ransom*, p. 28. Somax has a patronymic—‘son of Astrogon’ (p. 105)—but it is unknown to Priam and the royal household who never address him by his own name, let alone his father’s name.

²⁵ Malouf, *Ransom*, p. 223.

²⁶ Malouf, *Ransom*, p. 218.

²⁷ Gramsci Notebook 14 § 39 in Antonio Gramsci, *Selections from the Cultural Writings*, trans. W. Boelhower, ed. D. Forgacs and G. Nowell-Smith (Cambridge, Mass., 1991), p. 294. See Marcus Green, ‘Gramsci Cannot Speak: Presentations and Interpretations of Gramsci’s Concept of the Subaltern’, *Rethinking Marxism: A Journal of Economics, Culture & Society* 14:3 (2002), 1–24 (pp. 10–11), for discussion.

²⁸ Cf. Aimé Césaire, *Cahier d’un retour au pays natal (Notebook of a Return to my Native Land)*, trans., with introd. and notes, Clayton Eshleman and Annette Smith (Berkeley, 1983), p. 76: ‘et il est place pour tous au rendez-vous de la conquête’ (‘and there is room for everyone at the convocation of conquest’). The first edition of the *Cahier* was published in 1939.

²⁹ See e.g. Edith Hall, ‘Subjects, Selves, and Survivors’, *Helios* 34:2 (Fall 2007), 125–59 (p. 128), on references to the importance of reading Homer in the formation of many working class heroes in Jonathan Rose’s *The Intellectual Life of the British Working Classes* (New Haven, 2001).

³⁰ The emphasis on slavery in the *Iliad* is on the enslavement of women and children as captives of war. See Page Dubois, *Slaves and Other Objects* (Chicago, 2003), pp. 133–7 (‘Homer’s Slaves’). Hector famously predicts Andromache’s enslavement at *Iliad* 6.454–8. At 22.65 Priam anticipates the enslavement of the Trojan women after the fall of Troy, and when Andromache laments over Hector’s corpse she anticipates the Achaeans taking the women of Troy away in their ships (24.731–2) and the enslavement or death of their son Astyanax (24.732–5). However, there are also references to male captives taken in war, notably the references to Achilles selling the Trojan prince Lycaon (Priam’s son) into slavery 21.40–1, 58, and 78. For a discussion of the possibility of enslavement that attends Odysseus on his wandering in the *Odyssey*, and the ‘optical illusion’ that distracts readers from the possibility of Greek slavery in Homeric epic, see Patrice Rankine, ‘Odysseus as Slave: The Ritual of Domination and Social Death in

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Homeric Society’, in *Reading Ancient Slavery* ed. Richard Alston, Edith Hall, and Laura Proffitt (Bristol, 2011), pp. 34–50.

³¹ Malouf, *Ransom*, p. 75.

³² For general introductions to Walcott’s poetry and drama, see Edward Baugh, *Derek Walcott* (Cambridge, 2006); Paul Breslin, *Nobody’s Nation: Reading Derek Walcott* (Chicago, 2001); Paula Burnett, *Derek Walcott: Politics and Poetics* (Gainesville, Fla, 2000); Rei Terada, *Derek Walcott’s Poetry: American Mimicry* (Boston, 1992), and John Thieme, *Derek Walcott* (Manchester, 1999). The works cited above all contain discussions of *Omeros*; for specific studies, see Robert D. Hamner, *Epic of the Dispossessed: Derek Walcott’s Omeros* (Columbia, Mich., 1997); and *The Poetics of Derek Walcott: Intertextual perspectives* (= *South Atlantic Quarterly* 96:2 (Spring 1997)), edited by Gregson Davis, which contains five articles on *Omeros*. Rachel Friedman, ‘Derek Walcott’s *Odysseys*’, *International Journal of the Classical Tradition* 14:3 (Fall 2007), 455–80, and Justine McConnell, ‘The “Unread” Homer: Derek Walcott’s *Omeros* and *The Odyssey: A Stage Version*’, in Justine McConnell, *Black Odysseys: The Homeric Odyssey in the African Diaspora since 1939* (Oxford, 2013), both consider *Omeros* in relation to Walcott’s adaptation of the *Odyssey: The Odyssey: A Stage Version* (London, 1993).

³³ Or as focalized through the ghost of Warwick Walcott, imagining the perspective of the women who used to carry coal to the harbour in St Lucia: ‘they see their native town, | unknown, raw, insignificant’ (*Omeros* 1.XIII.iii; p. 75). The chronology of this scene is the early 1930s, when St Lucia was an underdeveloped British crown colony.

³⁴ See n. 28.

³⁵ *Omeros* 1.I.i; p. 3.

³⁶ *Omeros* 1.I.iii; p. 8.

³⁷ *Omeros* 1.III.i; p. 15: “‘*Touchez-i, encore: N’ai fendre choux-ous-ou, salope!*’ | ‘Touch it again, and I’ll split your arse, you bitch!’”

³⁸ *Omeros* 1.II.iii; p. 15.

³⁹ *Omeros* 2.XXII.ii; p. 117, ‘The comet, a sixteen-seater passenger-van | was the chariot that Hector bought.’ Hector is referred to as a ‘road-warrior’ when a fellow transport-driver tells the narrator about Hector’s death—his *kleos* (6.XLV.iii; p. 230).

⁴⁰ See e.g. Helen (7.LXIV.ii; p. 323): ‘She waits for your order and you lower your eyes | ~~Away~~ from hers that have never carried the spoil | ~~Of~~ Troy, that never betrayed horned Menelaus | ~~Or~~ netted Agamemnon in their irises.’

⁴¹ Derek Walcott, *The Arkansas Testament* (New York, 1987), pp. 34–5 (p. 35).

⁴² Gregson Davis, “‘With No Homeric Shadow’: The Disavowal of Epic in Derek Walcott’s *Omeros*”, *South Atlantic Quarterly* 96:2 (Spring 1997), 321–53, has referred to this overturning of expectations as ‘the disavowal of epic’, pointing to parallels with the classical rhetorical figure of *recusatio*. Paul Breslin, *Nobody’s Nation: Reading Derek Walcott* (Chicago, 2001), ch. 9 offers a good discussion of the credibility of Walcott’s critique of the Homeric parallels in the poem (see especially pp. 242–5 and 262–6).

⁴³ On the role of interpretative communities, see Helen Kaufmann, ‘Decolonizing the Postcolonial Colonizers: Helen in Derek Walcott’s *Omeros*’, in *Classics and the Uses of Reception*,

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ed. Charles Martindale and Richard F. Thomas, (Malden, Mass., 2006), pp. 192–203. Kaufmann analyses the role of the reader and receiver in identifying classical analogies in *Omeros*, using the character of Helen as a case study.

⁴⁴ *Omeros* 1.XII.i; p. 68.

⁴⁵ Lance Callahan, *In the Shadows of Divine Perfection: Derek Walcott's Omeros* (London, 2003), pp. 47–9.

⁴⁶ 1.XIII.iii; p. 75. The phrase ‘ancestral rhyme’ occurs early on the same page: ‘Kneel to your load, then balance your staggering feet | and walk up that coal ladder as they do in time, | one bare foot after the next in ancestral rhyme.’

⁴⁷ 1.XIII.iii; p. 75.

⁴⁸ See Rhonda Cobham-Sander, ‘“Any Enemy So Was a Compliment”: Walcott, Brathwaite and the Formal Possibilities of Creole’, in *Interlocking Basins of a Globe: Essays on Derek Walcott*, ed. Antoine-Dunne (Leeds, 2013), pp. 100–22 (pp. 112–15).

⁴⁹ *Omeros* 5.XXXVIII.iii; p. 197.

⁵⁰ *Omeros* 6.XLV.ii; p. 228. See also the related lines on the preceding page (p. 227): ‘Didn’t I want the poor | To stay in the same light so that I could transfix | them in amber, the after-glow of an empire, | preferring a shed of palm-thatch with tilted sticks | to that blue bus-stop? Didn’t I prefer a road | from which tracks climbed into the thickening syntax | of colonial travellers, the measured prose I read | as a schoolboy?’

⁵¹ *Omeros* 7.LXV.ii; p. 320.

⁵² *Omeros* 6.LIII.i; p. 265.

⁵³ *Omeros* 1.V.iii; p. 31.

⁵⁴ *Omeros* 1.V.iii; p. 30.

⁵⁵ *Omeros* 7.LXIV.ii; p. 323.

⁵⁶ Although *She Tries her Tongue* pre-dates *Omeros*, Philip explicitly distances herself from Derek Walcott (and Wilson Harris) in her introduction to the collection, eschewing their apparent comfort with the English language (p. 19). As it happened, in *Omeros* Walcott made a point of making formal, classical verse accommodate the St Lucian English Creole and Francophone Kweyol.

⁵⁷ Maria Christina Fumagalli, *Caribbean Perspectives on Modernity: Returning Medusa’s Gaze* (Charlottesville, Va, 2009), p. 74. Although, as the editors of this volume point out, north Atlantic Modernism offers powerful arguments for the dismantling of ideas of progress and traditional chronologies.

⁵⁸ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 25.

⁵⁹ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 21.

⁶⁰ Fumagalli *Caribbean Perspectives*, p. 74. As Fumagalli points out, the title of Philip’s collection is a quotation, from Dryden’s translation, of *Metamorphoses* 1.745–6, describing the aftermath of Io’s reverse metamorphosis back into her human form (Jupiter had transformed her into a heifer (1.610–11) after raping her (1.600), in order to evade detection by his wife Juno). The lines in question are: ‘*metuitque loqui, ne more iuvencae | mugiat, et timide verba intermissa retemptat*’—in Dryden’s translation: ‘She tries her tongue, her silence softly breaks, | And fears her former Lowings when she speaks.’

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⁶¹ Over fifty rapes are narrated in the *Metamorphoses* (the victims include men and women). See Amy Richlin, 'Reading Ovid's Rapes', in *Pornography and Representation in Greece and Rome*, ed. Amy Richlin (Oxford, 1992), pp. 158–79.

⁶² The '*mutatas formas*' (changed forms) and '*nova corpora*' (new bodies) referred to at *Met.* 1.1–2. On word play in Ovid see Frederick Ahl, *Metaformations: Soundplay and Wordplay in Ovid and Other Classical Poets* (Ithaca, NY, 1985).

⁶³ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 23.

⁶⁴ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 24.

⁶⁵ Philip envisages this process in terms of a metamorphosis within the language between formal and demotic English (*She Tries her Tongue*, p. 18).

⁶⁶ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 16; 'i-mage' is Philip's term, modelled on 'the Rastafarian practice of privileging the 'I' in many words' (p. 12).

⁶⁷ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 29.

⁶⁸ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 31.

⁶⁹ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, pp. 52–3.

⁷⁰ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 48. The etymological connection between 'muse' and 'museum' (Grk. *mouseion*, home of the muses) is sound, but the superficial connection between 'mute' and 'muse' is pseudo-etymological.

⁷¹ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 56.

⁷² Evelyn O'Callaghan, *Woman Version: Theoretical Approaches to West Indian Fiction by Women* (London, 1993), pp. 10–11.

⁷³ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, quoting from p. 58 and p. 73 respectively.

⁷⁴ Philip, *She Tries her Tongue*, p. 98.

⁷⁵ See Lorna Hardwick, 'Fuzzy Connections: Classical Texts and Modern Poetry in English', in *Tradition, Translation, Trauma: The Classic and the Modern*, ed. Jan Parker and Timothy Matthews (Oxford, 2011), pp. 39–60 (p. 50), for the idea of 'classical connectivity'—a shorthand term to describe the way in which adaptations of and responses to classical works enable writers to combine local traditions with transnational and trans-historical themes.

⁷⁶ See n. 78.

⁷⁷ Toni Morrison, *Beloved* (New York, 1987).

⁷⁸ Morrison, *Beloved*, p. 205.

⁷⁹ The proximate source for the plot of *Beloved* is the history of Margaret Garner, the escaped slave who committed infanticide when her former owners tried to claim her children as their property. See Morrison, *Beloved*, p. xvii (Foreword). Abolitionists championed Margaret Garner's cause and, on the basis of a painting by Thomas Satterwhite Noble's, Garner gained the tag 'the Modern Medea'. For classical receptions in abolitionists' representations of Margaret Garner's actions, see Margaret Malamud, 'The *Auctoritas* of Antiquity: Debating Slavery through Classical Exempla in the Antebellum USA', in *Ancient Slavery and Abolition: From Hobbes to Hollywood*, ed. Edith Hall, Richard Alston, and Justine McConnell (Oxford, 2011), pp. 279–317 (pp. 294–6).

⁸⁰ As Jason (hardly a reliable commentator) remarks of Medea's actions at line 1139 of Euripides' play, 'there is no Greek woman who would do this thing'. Euripides staging of this

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play at the heart of a Greek city and the play's valorization of Medea's heroism, no matter how dreadful, poses a profound challenge to Jason's assumption.

⁸¹ Morrison, *Beloved*, p. xviii.

⁸² Lost language: Sethe dimly recalls the woman, Nan, who minded her while her mother worked, speaking to her in another, forgotten language (p. 74): 'What Nan told her she had forgotten, along with the language she told it in. The same language her ma'am spoke, and which would never come back.' Renaming: Inquiring after the name 'Jenny' by which Mr. Garner addresses her, Baby Suggs is told 'Cause that what's on your sales ticket, gal' (p. 167).

⁸³ Morrison in Michael Silverblatt, "'Things We Find in Language': A Conversation with Toni Morrison", in *Conversations with Toni Morrison*, ed. Carolyn C. Denard (Jackson, Mich., 2008), pp. 171–7 (p. 175). This is a reprint of an interview that took place in 1998.

⁸⁴ Morrison, *Beloved*, p. 44.

⁸⁵ Morrison, *Beloved*, p. 183.

⁸⁶ Judylyn S. Ryan, 'Language and Narrative Technique in Toni Morrison's Novels', in *The Cambridge Companion to Toni Morrison*, ed. Justine Tally (Cambridge, 2007), pp. 151–61 (p. 159), quoting Judylyn S. Ryan, *Spirituality as Ideology in Black Women's Film and Literature* (Charlottesville, Va, 2005), p. 18.

⁸⁷ Ralph Ellison, 'The Little Man at Chehaw Station: The American Artist and his Audience', *American Scholar* 47:1 (Winter 1977–8), pp. 25–48 (p. 31).

⁸⁸ Cf. Charles Segal, *Dionysiac Poetics and Euripides' Bacchae* (Princeton, 1982), p. 25, 'Euripides' feeling for the tragic antinomies of life... finds its clearest expression in doubling, the pairing of opposites, and the sliding of opposites into one another.' These binary opposites include 'Greek: foreign', 'god: human', 'human: beast', 'agent: victim', etc.

⁸⁹ Toni Morrison, 'Unspeakable Things Unspoken: The Afro-American Presence in American Literature', *Michigan Quarterly Review* 28:1 (1989), 1–34. Originally delivered as the Tanner Lectures on Human Values at the University of Michigan, 7 October 1988.

⁹⁰ Compare Rita Dove on working with the ancient Greek dramatic form when adapting Sophocles' *Oedipus Rex* for her play *The Darker Face of the Earth*: 'I'd grown up in the Black church, where call-and-response was part of the ritual... Running commentary provided by the Greek chorus sounds "down home" to me.' Dove, interviewed by Robert McDowell in 2000 (quoting Robert McDowell, 'Language is not Enough: An Interview with Rita Dove', in *Conversations with Rita Dove*, ed. Earl G. Ingersoll (Jackson, Mich., 2003), pp. 174–9 (pp. 175–6).

⁹¹ Tessa Roynon, *Toni Morrison & the Classical Tradition: Transforming American Culture* (Oxford, 2013), p. 82.

⁹² Morrison, *Beloved*, p. 27. The next sentence reads: 'Anybody Baby Suggs knew, let alone loved, who hadn't run off or been hanged, got rented out, loaned out, bought up, brought back, stored up, mortgaged, won, stolen or seized' (*ibid.*).

⁹³ Morrison, *Beloved*, p. 194.

⁹⁴ Morrison, *Beloved*, p. 277. In interviews, Morrison refrains from passing judgement on the morality of Sethe's actions. There is a sense in which a universal logic of motherhood is not sufficient to explain Sethe's actions, since, as Hazel Carby has discussed, there were very

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significant differences in motherhood as experienced by enslaved black women and motherhood as experienced by their white counterparts: ‘As a slave, the black woman was in an entirely different relation to the plantation patriarch. Her reproductive destiny was bound to capital accumulation; black women gave birth to property and, directly, to capital itself in the form of slaves, and all slaves inherited their status from their mothers.’ Hazel Carby, *Reconstructing Womanhood: The Emergence of the Afro-American Woman Novelist* (New York, 1987), quoting from pp. 24–5.

⁹⁵ Rita Dove, *Mother Love: Poems* (New York, 1995). Compare Tracey L. Walters, *African American Literature and the Classicist Tradition: Black Women Writers from Wheatley to Morrison* (Basingstoke, 2007), p. 170, and ch. 5 *passim*, for an intertextual reading of Morrison, Dove (and Gwendolyn Brooks), in this case reading echoes of the Demeter and Persephone myth in Morrison’s *The Bluest Eye* (1970) in dialogue with Dove’s treatment of the myth in *Mother Love*.

⁹⁶ Compare Philip’s reception of the myth discussed in ‘Ovidian experiments with subaltern speech’ above.

⁹⁷ Dove, *Mother Love*, p. 13.

⁹⁸ Dove in Wayne Ude, ‘Having the Picture Coalesce in a Kind of Whoosh!’, in *Conversations with Rita Dove*, ed. Earl G. Ingersoll (Jackson, Mich., 2003), pp. 88–102 (p. 97).

⁹⁹ Dove, *Mother Love*, p. 55.

¹⁰⁰ Dove, *Mother Love*, p. 15. NCMEC—the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children—was established in 1983 by Ronald Reagan and the milk carton campaign, displaying the photos of missing children, began in 1984 and ran throughout the 1980s. In the context of recent African American history, the reference to the milk carton campaign also brings to mind the Atlanta child murders of 1979–81, which saw the abduction, murder, and molestation of twenty-nine African American children and widespread criticism of the failings of the police investigation, and ~~was one of the major contributors~~ to the founding of the NCMEC.

¹⁰¹ Dove, *Mother Love*, p. 62.

¹⁰² Dove, *Mother Love*, quoting from p. 13 and p. 55 respectively.

¹⁰³ Dove, *Mother Love*, p. 19 and p. 61 respectively.

¹⁰⁴ Baker, *Blues, Ideology, and Afro-American Literature*, p. 5, ‘The blues are a synthesis (albeit one always synthesizing rather than one already hypostatized). Combining work songs, group seculars, field hollers, sacred harmonies, proverbial wisdom, folk philosophy, political commentary, ribald humour, elegiac lament, and much more . . .’ For the ‘blues matrix’ see *ibid*, p. 14. On blues culture, see further the seminal study of Albert Murray, *Stomping the Blues* (New York, 1976).

¹⁰⁵ Dove, *Mother Love*, p. 33, and pp. 40–2 respectively.

¹⁰⁶ On the translatability of this myth in contemporary woman’s poetry, see Isobel Hurst, ‘“Love and Blackmail”: Demeter and Persephone’, *Classical Receptions Journal* 4:2—Special issue on contemporary women authors and classical reception, guest ed. Fiona Cox and Elena Theodorakopoulos (2012), pp. 176–89.

¹⁰⁷ Dove in Steven Bellin, ‘A Conversation with Rita Dove’, *Mississippi Review* 23:3 (Spring 1995), 10–35 (p. 23).

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¹⁰⁸ Cf. Ellison, ‘The Little Man at Chehaw Station’, p. 33 on American democracy as ‘not only a political collectivity of individuals but, culturally, a collectivity of styles, tastes, and traditions’.

¹⁰⁹ Dove, *Mother Love*, p. 13.

¹¹⁰ William W. Cook and James Tatum, *African American Writers & Classical Tradition* (Chicago, 2010), pp. 341–75 offer a good discussion of the range of literary allusions in *Mother Love*.

¹¹¹ Dove, *Mother Love*, p. 17. The primary source text for this myth is the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* (lines 105–300), which recounts the myth about Demeter in distress at losing her daughter Persephone trying to assuage her mothering instinct by assuming the role of nurse. She is taken on as a nurse for Demophoön, the only, late-born son of Celsus and Metaneira, and secretes him in the fire each night as a means of ensuring eternal life.

¹¹² In ‘Her Island’, the narrator refers to her black skin explicitly on p. 69, ‘hasn’t he seen an America black | before?’, followed by ‘I’m surely his first | Queen of Sheba’ on p. 70.

¹¹³ The relevant lines in the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* are 239–41 (‘each night she would hide him away in the burning fire, like a brand, without his dear parents’ knowledge’), and Metaneira’s response at 248–9 (‘Demophoön, my child, the visitor is hiding you away in the blazing fire, causing me groaning and grief’). Translated by Martin L. West, *Homeric Hymns, Homeric Apocrypha, Lives of Homer*, Loeb Classical Library (Cambridge, Mass., 2003).

¹¹⁴ Cook and Tatum, *African American Writers & Classical Tradition*, pp. 354–5 describe the image of the Virginia ham as ‘a hilarious riff on what is for moderns the most bizarre moment in the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*—certainly the most magical’.

¹¹⁵ Ellison, ‘The Little Man at Chehaw Station’, p. 30.

